Learn Radicals

The 214 Building Blocks of Chinese

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INTRODUCTION

Chinese has a system.
This guide shows you what it is.

Chinese characters aren't random. They're built from a small set of recurring visual pieces called **radicals**. There are 214 in the standard Kangxi system — each carrying a core meaning: water, fire, heart, hand, mouth. When you spot a radical inside a character, it tells you what that character is about before you even know the word.

How characters are built

Most Chinese characters (~80–90%) are built from two pieces:

- **Radical** — hints at meaning. See 氵 on the left? Probably water. See 忄? Probably a feeling.
- **Phonetic component** — hints at pronunciation. These aren't a fixed set; you absorb them naturally as you learn more characters.

Take 河 (hé, river). The left side is 氵, the water radical — that's your meaning clue. The right side is 可 (kě) — that's the phonetic component hinting at pronunciation.

From components to words

Chinese is modular at every level. A small number of components combine into characters, and characters combine into words:

- **Components → Characters:** 氵 (water) + 可 (kě) = 河 (river). A few hundred components produce thousands of characters.
- **Characters → Words:** Most modern Chinese words are two characters combined. 火 (fire) + 车 (vehicle) = 火车 (train). 电 (electric) + 话 (speech) = 电话 (telephone).

The meaning logic carries through. The water radical 氵 appears in 河 (river), 海 (sea), 湖 (lake) — and those characters then form words like 海鲜 (seafood), 湖边 (lakeside), 河水 (river water). One radical connects a whole web of vocabulary.

Why study radicals?

Phonetic components number in the thousands and are best learned through exposure. Radicals are different — there are only 214, and maybe 50–60 really common ones. They're a small enough set to study deliberately. Learn them, and every new character starts making more sense. That's what this guide is for.

About this guide

Every radical is organized into 31 themed families and paired with example characters showing the pattern in action. Each entry also includes the radical's Chinese name in pinyin — this is what native speakers say when describing how to write a character.

Radicals are shown in simplified Chinese. Of the 214, the vast majority look identical in both systems — only about 11 changed during simplification. Where the forms differ, the traditional appears in brackets, marked with *.

Quick example

water radical (sān diǎn shuǐ — three dots of water)

河 river · 海 sea · 泪 tears · 酒 alcohol

See 氵 on the left of each character? It's related to water.

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A **Quick Reference — All Radicals by Stroke Count**

01 Strokes & Basics

The most elemental building blocks — basic strokes and simple forms that appear inside thousands of characters.

一 one / horizontal (héng — horizontal stroke)

万	wàn	ten thousand	天	tiān	sky / day
百	bǎi	hundred	下	xià	below

丨 vertical stroke (shù — vertical stroke)

中	zhōng	middle	丰	fēng	abundant
旧	jiù	old			

丶 dot (diǎn — dot)

丸	wán	pill	主	zhǔ	main / host
太	tài	too / great			

丿 left-falling stroke (piě — left-falling stroke)

久	jiǔ	long time	乏	fá	lacking
乐	lè	happy			

乙 second / turning (yǐ — second / turning)

九	jiǔ	nine	也	yě	also
乾	qián	dry / heaven			

亅 hook (jué — hook)

了	le	completed	予	yǔ	to give
事	shì	matter			

二 **two** (èr — two)

互	hù	mutual	元	yuán	yuan / origin
云	yún	cloud			

八 **eight / divide** (bā — eight / divide)

分	fēn	divide	公	gōng	public
兴	xīng	prosper			

十 **ten / cross** (shí — ten / cross)

早	zǎo	early	古	gǔ	ancient
南	nán	south	博	bó	extensive

02 Water & Ice

Characters connected to water, liquids, ice, and flowing.

氵 **water (side form)** (sān diǎn shuǐ — three dots of water)

河	hé	river	海	hǎi	sea
湖	hú	lake	泪	lèi	tears
汗	hàn	sweat	洗	xǐ	to wash
游	yóu	to swim	酒	jiǔ	alcohol

水 **water** (shuǐ — water)

泉	quán	spring	浆	jiāng	thick liquid
泰	tài	peaceful	浸	jìn	to soak
淼	miǎo	vast water			

冫 **ice** (liǎng diǎn shuǐ — two dots of ice)

冷	lěng	cold	冻	dòng	to freeze
凉	liáng	cool	冰	bīng	ice
凋	diāo	to wither	净	jìng	clean

雨 **rain** (yǔ zì tóu — rain on top)

雪	xuě	snow	雷	léi	thunder
雾	wù	fog	霜	shuāng	frost
露	lù	dew	震	zhèn	to shake

巛 **river / stream** (sān guǎi — three bends)

巡	xún	to patrol	灾	zāi	disaster
顺	shùn	smooth			

川 **river** (chuān — river)

州	zhōu	state / province	巡	xún	to patrol
训	xùn	to train			

03 Fire & Heat

Characters connected to fire, cooking, heat, and light.

火 **fire** (huǒ zì páng — fire side)

灯	dēng	lamp	灶	zào	stove
炒	chǎo	stir-fry	烤	kǎo	roast
烧	shāo	burn	炸	zhà	explode / deep-fry
灭	miè	extinguish	炎	yán	inflammation

灬 **fire (bottom form)** (sì diǎn dǐ — four dots on bottom)

热	rè	hot	煮	zhǔ	to boil
蒸	zhēng	to steam	照	zhào	to shine
熊	xióng	bear	煎	jiān	to pan-fry
焦	jiāo	burnt / anxious			

光 **light / ray** (guāng — light)

辉	huī	radiance	亮	liàng	bright
焰	yàn	flame	耀	yào	to shine

04 Air & Weather

Characters connected to air, wind, and flight.

气 **air / gas** (qì — air / gas)

氧	yǎng	oxygen	氛	fēn	atmosphere
氢	qīng	hydrogen	氮	dàn	nitrogen

风 （風） **wind** (fēng — wind)

* Traditional form in brackets

飓	jù	hurricane	飘	piāo	to float
刮	guā	to blow (wind)			

飞 **fly** (fēi — fly)

翔	xiáng	to soar	翅	chì	wing
航	háng	to navigate			

05 Earth, Stone & Land

Characters connected to ground, soil, mountains, and stone.

土 **earth / soil** (tí tǔ páng — raised earth side)

地	dì	ground	城	chéng	city
场	chǎng	field / place	坐	zuò	to sit
墙	qiáng	wall	堆	duī	pile

山 **mountain** (shān zì páng — mountain side)

岛	dǎo	island	岸	àn	shore
峰	fēng	peak	崩	bēng	collapse
岩	yán	rock / cliff			

石 **stone / rock** (shí zì páng — stone side)

砖	zhuān	brick	破	pò	to break
碗	wǎn	bowl	确	què	certain
矿	kuàng	mine / ore			

田 **field** (tián zì páng — field side)

男	nán	male	思	sī	to think
留	liú	to stay	亩	mǔ	acre
畜	chù	livestock			

里 **village / inside** (lǐ — village / inside)

野	yě	wild	理	lǐ	reason / manage
量	liàng	measure	重	zhòng	heavy

谷 **valley** (gǔ — valley)

峪	yù	valley	豁	huō	open / clear
容	róng	contain / face			

艮 **mountain / stubborn** (gèn — mountain / stubborn)

根	gēn	root	很	hěn	very
银	yín	silver	限	xiàn	limit

06 Sun & Time

Characters connected to the sun, light, time, and speaking.

日 sun / day (rì zì páng — sun/day side)

明	míng	bright	早	zǎo	early
晚	wǎn	evening	时	shí	time
暖	nuǎn	warm	春	chūn	spring
暗	àn	dark			

曰 to say

曷	hé	why	最	zuì	most
曹	cáo	group / surname			

夕 evening / sunset (xī — evening)

多	duō	many	外	wài	outside
夜	yè	night	岁	suì	year / age
名	míng	name			

白 white / bright (bái zì páng — white side)

百	bǎi	hundred	的	de	(possessive)
皇	huáng	emperor	泉	quán	spring

07 Wood & Trees

Characters connected to wood, trees, bamboo, and vegetation.

木 wood / tree (mù zì páng — wood side)

林	lín	forest	树	shù	tree
板	bǎn	board	桌	zhuō	table
桥	qiáo	bridge	根	gēn	root
椅	yǐ	chair			

竹 **bamboo** (zhú zì tóu — bamboo on top)

笔	bǐ	pen	筷	kuài	chopsticks
笑	xiào	to laugh	篮	lán	basket
简	jiǎn	simple	算	suàn	to calculate

艹 **grass / plant** (cǎo zì tóu — grass on top)

花	huā	flower	草	cǎo	grass
茶	chá	tea	药	yào	medicine
菜	cài	vegetable	蓝	lán	blue
苦	kǔ	bitter			

禾 **grain / crop** (hé mù páng — grain side)

种	zhǒng	seed / to plant	秋	qiū	autumn
秀	xiù	elegant	科	kē	subject / branch
积	jī	accumulate			

米 **rice / grain** (mǐ zì páng — rice side)

粉	fěn	powder	粗	cū	rough / thick
糖	táng	sugar	精	jīng	refined / spirit
糊	hú	paste			

瓜 **melon** (guā zì páng — melon side)

瓢	piáo	ladle	瓣	bàn	petal / segment

屮 **sprout** (chè — sprout)

芽	yá	bud	草	cǎo	grass

08 Crops, Food & Taste

Characters connected to grains, food, drink, and flavor.

麦 **wheat** (mài — wheat)

面	miàn	noodle / face	麸	fū	bran

麻 **hemp** (má — hemp)

磨	mó	to grind	摩	mó	to rub / friction
魔	mó	demon			

黍 **millet** (shǔ — millet)

黏	nián	sticky	黎	lí	many / surname

韭 **leek** (jiǔ — leek)

韮	jiǔ	chive (variant)

豆 **bean** (dòu — bean)

豆腐	dòu	tofu (as component)	短	duǎn	short
丰	fēng	abundant			

甘 **sweet** (gān — sweet)

甜	tián	sweet	某	mǒu	certain / some
甚	shèn	very			

食 **food**

饮	yǐn	to drink	饭	fàn	rice / meal
饱	bǎo	full (stomach)	饿	è	hungry
馒	mán	steamed bun	饺	jiǎo	dumpling

饣 (食)

food (side form) (shí zì páng — food side)

* Traditional form in brackets

饮	yǐn	to drink	饥	jī	hungry
饰	shì	to decorate			

卤 (鹵)

salt / brine (lǔ zì páng — salt / brine)

* Traditional form in brackets

咸	xián	salty	盐	yán	salt

酉

wine jar / ferment (yǒu — wine jar)

醉	zuì	drunk	酱	jiàng	sauce
醋	cù	vinegar	酸	suān	sour
酿	niàng	to brew			

09 Metal & Treasure

Characters connected to metal, gold, jade, and value.

钅 (金)

metal / gold (side) (jīn zì páng — gold/metal side)

* Traditional form in brackets

钱	qián	money	银	yín	silver
铁	tiě	iron	铜	tóng	copper
锅	guō	pot / wok	锁	suǒ	lock
镜	jìng	mirror	针	zhēn	needle

金

gold / metal (jīn — gold / metal)

鑫	xīn	prosperity	鉴	jiàn	mirror / inspect
釜	fǔ	cauldron			

玉 **jade / gem** (wáng zì páng — king side (looks like 王))

珠	zhū	pearl	球	qiú	ball
理	lǐ	reason	现	xiàn	appear
环	huán	ring / circle	瑰	guī	precious

贝 （貝） **shell / value** (bèi zì páng — shell side)

* Traditional form in brackets

财	cái	wealth	购	gòu	to buy
贵	guì	expensive	贫	pín	poor
赚	zhuàn	to earn	账	zhàng	account
贸	mào	trade			

10 Color & Pattern

Characters connected to colors, appearance, and visual qualities.

色 **color** (sè — color)

绝	jué	absolute	艳	yàn	gorgeous

青 **blue-green** (qīng — blue-green)

清	qīng	clear	请	qǐng	please
情	qíng	emotion	晴	qíng	sunny
静	jìng	quiet			

黄 **yellow** (huáng — yellow)

横	héng	horizontal	簧	huáng	spring (coil)

黑 **black** (hēi — black)

墨	mò	ink	默	mò	silent
黛	dài	black pigment			

赤 **red / bare** (chì — red / bare)

赫 hè impressive
赦 shè to pardon

玄 **dark / mysterious** (xuán — dark / mysterious)

弦 xián string (instrument)
畜 chù livestock
率 lǜ rate

彡 **hair / bristle / pattern** (shān — hair / bristle)

形 xíng shape
影 yǐng shadow
彩 cǎi colorful
须 xū must / beard

11 Person & Posture

Characters showing people, stature, and positions.

亻 **person (side form)** (dān rén páng — single person side)

他 tā he
你 nǐ you
住 zhù to live
做 zuò to do
信 xìn trust / letter
休 xiū to rest

人 **person** (rén zì tóu — person on top)

从 cóng from / follow
今 jīn today
会 huì to meet / can
合 hé to combine
全 quán whole

大 **big / great** (dà zì tóu — big on top)

太 tài too
天 tiān sky
央 yāng center
奇 qí strange
奖 jiǎng prize / reward

小 **small** (xiǎo zì tóu — small on top)

少	shǎo	few	尖	jiān	sharp / pointed
尘	chén	dust			

立 **stand** (lì zì páng — standing side)

站	zhàn	station / to stand	竞	jìng	compete
端	duān	end / proper	章	zhāng	chapter

尸 **corpse / body** (shī zì tóu — corpse on top)

层	céng	layer	居	jū	to reside
屋	wū	room	展	zhǎn	to unfold
尾	wěi	tail	屏	píng	screen

儿 **child / legs** (ér zì dǐ — child legs on bottom)

兄	xiōng	older brother	元	yuán	origin / yuan
先	xiān	first	光	guāng	light
克	kè	to overcome			

入 **enter** (rù — enter)

全	quán	whole	内	nèi	inside
肉	ròu	meat			

比 **compare** (bǐ — compare)

批	pī	to criticize	毕	bì	to complete
皆	jiē	all			

臣 **minister / servant** (chén — minister)

臨	lín	to face / approach	卧	wò	to lie down
藏	cáng	to hide			

12 Body & Organs

Characters connected to the body, flesh, bones, and physical features.

月 **flesh / body** (ròu yuè páng — flesh-moon side)

胖	pàng	fat
脸	liǎn	face
脑	nǎo	brain
肚	dù	belly
肝	gān	liver
脚	jiǎo	foot
腿	tuǐ	leg

肉 **meat / flesh** (ròu — meat / flesh)

腐	fǔ	rotten
膏	gāo	ointment / fat
腰	yāo	waist

身 **body** (shēn zì páng — body side)

躺	tǎng	to lie down
躲	duǒ	to hide
射	shè	to shoot

自 **self / nose (original)** (zì — self)

息	xī	breath / rest
臭	chòu	stinky
鼻	bí	nose

首 **head / leader** (shǒu — head / leader)

道	dào	way / road
导	dǎo	to guide

面 **face / surface** (miàn — face)

面条	miàn	noodle (component)

骨 **bone** (gǔ — bone)

骼	gé	skeleton	髓	suǐ	marrow
骸	hái	bones / remains			

血 **blood** (xuè — blood)

衅	xìn	quarrel	衄	nǜ	nosebleed

齿（齿） **tooth** (chǐ — tooth)

* Traditional form in brackets

龄	líng	age	龋	qǔ	tooth decay
啮	niè	to gnaw			

鼻 **nose** (bí — nose)

鼾	hān	snore	齁	qiú	stuffy nose

髟 **long hair** (biāo — long hair)

髮	fà	hair	鬓	bìn	sideburns
鬣	liè	mane			

毛 **fur / hair** (máo — fur / hair)

毯	tǎn	blanket	毫	háo	tiny / brush tip
笔	bǐ	pen	毽	jiàn	shuttlecock

欠 **owe / yawn** (qiàn — owe / yawn)

次	cì	next / time	歌	gē	song
欢	huān	happy	欲	yù	desire
款	kuǎn	money / style			

13 Mouth & Speech

Characters connected to the mouth, speaking, and sounds.

口 **mouth** (kǒu zì páng — mouth side)

吃	chī	to eat	喝	hē	to drink
叫	jiào	to call	唱	chàng	to sing
味	wèi	taste	吹	chuī	to blow
哭	kū	to cry	嘴	zuǐ	mouth / lips

讠（言） **speech (side form)** (yán zì páng — speech side)

* Traditional form in brackets

说	shuō	to speak	话	huà	speech / word
语	yǔ	language	读	dú	to read
谢	xiè	thanks	认	rèn	recognize
让	ràng	let / allow	讨	tǎo	discuss / beg

音 **sound** (yīn — sound)

暗	àn	dark	意	yì	meaning
韵	yùn	rhyme	章	zhāng	chapter

舌 **tongue** (shé — tongue)

话	huà	speech	活	huó	alive
甜	tián	sweet	舔	tiǎn	to lick
乱	luàn	chaotic			

14 Heart & Mind

Characters connected to emotions, thinking, and feelings.

忄 heart (side form) (shù xīn páng — vertical heart side)

快	kuài	fast / happy	慢	màn	slow
怕	pà	afraid	情	qíng	emotion
忙	máng	busy	悟	wù	to realize
惊	jīng	startled	恨	hèn	to hate

心 heart (xīn zì dǐ — heart on bottom)

想	xiǎng	to think / miss	思	sī	to think
感	gǎn	to feel	意	yì	meaning / intention
愿	yuàn	willing / wish	念	niàn	to miss / read
忘	wàng	to forget	态	tài	attitude

15 Hand & Action

Characters connected to hands, gripping, effort, and doing.

扌 hand (side form) (tí shǒu páng — raised hand side)

打	dǎ	to hit	拉	lā	to pull
抓	zhuā	to grab	推	tuī	to push
拿	ná	to take	找	zhǎo	to find
把	bǎ	to hold	投	tóu	to throw

手 hand (shǒu — hand)

拳	quán	fist	掌	zhǎng	palm
拜	bài	to worship	挚	zhì	sincere

力 **power / strength** (lì zì páng — power side)

动	dòng	to move	加	jiā	to add
努	nǔ	to strive	助	zhù	to help
功	gōng	achievement	办	bàn	to handle

工 **work / craft** (gōng zì páng — work side)

左	zuǒ	left	功	gōng	merit
项	xiàng	item / neck	巧	qiǎo	clever
差	chà	lacking / difference			

又 **right hand / again** (yòu zì páng — right-hand side)

友	yǒu	friend	对	duì	correct
双	shuāng	pair	欢	huān	happy
取	qǔ	to take			

支 **branch / support** (zhī — branch / support)

技	jì	skill	枝	zhī	branch
肢	zhī	limb			

攴 **strike / tap** (pū — strike / tap)

放	fàng	to release	政	zhèng	politics
教	jiào	to teach	散	sàn	to scatter

廾 **two hands (joined)** (gǒng — two hands joined)

开	kāi	to open	弄	nòng	to play with
弁	biàn	cap			

聿 brush / pen (yù — brush / pen)

书	shū	book	律	lǜ	law
建	jiàn	to build			

16 Foot & Movement

Characters connected to feet, walking, running, and movement.

足 foot (zú zì páng — foot side)

跑	pǎo	to run	跳	tiào	to jump
路	lù	road	踢	tī	to kick
跟	gēn	to follow	蹲	dūn	to squat

辶 walk (bottom form) (zǒu zhī dǐ — walk-this bottom)

这	zhè	this	过	guò	to pass
还	hái	still / return	进	jìn	enter
远	yuǎn	far	送	sòng	to send
逃	táo	to escape	速	sù	speed

走 walk / run (zǒu zì páng — walk side)

起	qǐ	to rise	赶	gǎn	to rush
超	chāo	to exceed	越	yuè	to cross / exceed
趣	qù	interest			

彳 step (left foot) (shuāng rén páng — double person side)

行	xíng	to walk	很	hěn	very
往	wǎng	toward	得	dé	to get
街	jiē	street	德	dé	virtue

止 **stop** (zhǐ zì páng — stop side)

步	bù	step	正	zhèng	straight / correct
此	cǐ	this	武	wǔ	martial
歪	wāi	crooked			

夂 **go / follow** (zhǐ — go / follow)

冬	dōng	winter	处	chù	place
各	gè	each			

夊 **go slowly** (suī — go slowly)

夏	xià	summer	复	fù	to repeat / again

廴 **long stride** (yǐn — long stride)

建	jiàn	to build	延	yán	to extend

癶 **footsteps (diverging)** (bō — footsteps)

登	dēng	to climb	发	fā	to emit / hair

舛 **oppose / contrary** (chuǎn — oppose / contrary)

舞	wǔ	to dance	舜	shùn	sage-king Shun

至 **arrive / reach** (zhì — arrive / reach)

到	dào	to arrive	致	zhì	to cause
室	shì	room			

行 **walk / go / do** (xíng — walk / go)

街	jiē	street	衡	héng	balance
衍	yǎn	to spread			

17 Eye & Perception

Characters connected to seeing, hearing, and awareness.

目 **eye** (mù zì páng — eye side)

看	kàn	to look	眼	yǎn	eye
睡	shuì	to sleep	盲	máng	blind
眉	méi	eyebrow	瞬	shùn	blink / instant

见 （見） **see** (jiàn zì páng — see side)

* Traditional form in brackets

观	guān	to watch	视	shì	to view
现	xiàn	to appear	规	guī	rule
觉	jué	to feel / aware			

示 **show / spirit** (shì zì páng — show/spirit side)

祝	zhù	to wish / bless	神	shén	god / spirit
社	shè	society	礼	lǐ	ritual / gift
祖	zǔ	ancestor	福	fú	blessing

耳 **ear** (ěr zì páng — ear side)

听	tīng	to listen	聪	cōng	clever
闻	wén	to hear / smell	职	zhí	duty / job
联	lián	to connect			

罒 **net (top form)** (sì zì tóu — four on top (net))

罗	luó	net / arrange	罪	zuì	crime / sin
署	shǔ	office	置	zhì	to place
蜀	shǔ	Sichuan			

18 Woman & Family

Characters connected to women, children, family, and generations.

女 **woman** (nǚ zì páng — woman side)

妈	mā	mother	她	tā	she
好	hǎo	good	姐	jiě	older sister
妹	mèi	younger sister	婚	hūn	marriage
姓	xìng	surname			

子 **child / seed** (zǐ zì páng — child side)

学	xué	to study	字	zì	character
孩	hái	child	孙	sūn	grandchild
存	cún	to save / exist	孤	gū	orphan / lonely

父 **father** (fù zì tóu — father on top)

爸	bà	dad	爷	yé	grandfather
爹	diē	father (informal)			

老 **old / elder** (lǎo zì tóu — old on top)

考	kǎo	exam / test	者	zhě	one who
孝	xiào	filial piety			

氏 **clan / family** (shì — clan)

民	mín	people	纸	zhǐ	paper
婚	hūn	marriage			

19 Animals — Land

Characters connected to land animals, livestock, and wild creatures.

犭 **animal (side form)** (fǎn quǎn páng — reversed dog side)

狗	gǒu	dog	猫	māo	cat
猪	zhū	pig	狼	láng	wolf
猴	hóu	monkey	狮	shī	lion
独	dú	alone	狂	kuáng	crazy

犬 **dog** (quǎn — dog)

哭	kū	to cry	器	qì	instrument
状	zhuàng	shape / condition	献	xiàn	to offer

马 （馬） **horse** (mǎ zì páng — horse side)

* Traditional form in brackets

骑	qí	to ride	驾	jià	to drive
驻	zhù	to station	骗	piàn	to cheat
驴	lǘ	donkey			

牛 **ox / cow** (niú zì páng — ox side)

牧	mù	to herd	物	wù	thing / object
特	tè	special	牺	xī	sacrifice
犁	lí	plow			

羊 **sheep / goat** (yáng zì páng — sheep side)

美	měi	beautiful	鲜	xiān	fresh
群	qún	group	羞	xiū	shy / shame
善	shàn	good / kind	义	yì	righteousness

豕 **pig** (shǐ — pig)

家	jiā	home / family	象	xiàng	elephant / image
蒙	méng	to cover / naive			

鹿 **deer** (lù — deer)

麓	lù	foot of mountain	丽	lì	beautiful
庆	qìng	celebrate			

鼠 **rat / mouse** (shǔ — rat)

鼬	yòu	weasel

虎 **tiger stripes** (hǔ — tiger stripes)

虎	hǔ	tiger	虑	lǜ	to worry
虐	nüè	to abuse	虚	xū	empty / false

豸 **badger / beast** (zhì — badger / beast)

貌	mào	appearance	豹	bào	leopard
貉	hé	raccoon dog			

20 Animals — Sky & Water

Characters connected to birds, fish, insects, and reptiles.

鸟 （鳥） **bird** (niǎo zì páng — bird side)

* Traditional form in brackets

鸡	jī	chicken	鸭	yā	duck
鹅	é	goose	鸽	gē	pigeon
鹰	yīng	eagle	鹤	hè	crane

鱼 （魚） **fish** (yú zì páng — fish side)

* Traditional form in brackets

鲜	xiān	fresh	鲸	jīng	whale
鳄	è	crocodile	鲤	lǐ	carp
鲨	shā	shark			

虫 **insect / bug** (chóng zì páng — insect side)

蛇	shé	snake	蝴蝶	hú	butterfly (component)
蚊	wén	mosquito	蜜	mì	honey
蛋	dàn	egg	蚂蚁	mǎ	ant (component)

隹 **short-tailed bird** (zhuī — short-tailed bird)

雀	què	sparrow	集	jí	to gather
难	nán	difficult	准	zhǔn	accurate
雄	xióng	male / heroic	雅	yǎ	elegant

龟 （龜） **turtle** (guī — turtle)

* Traditional form in brackets

龟裂	jūn	to crack (component)

龙 （龍） **dragon** (lóng — dragon)

* Traditional form in brackets

笼	lóng	cage	聋	lóng	deaf
宠	chǒng	to pamper / pet			

黽 **frog / toad** (mǐn — frog / toad)

鼋	yuán	soft-shell turtle	蝇	yíng	fly (insect)

21 Feather, Claw & Horn

Characters connected to animal features and materials from animals.

羽 **feather** (yǔ — feather)

翅	chì	wing	翔	xiáng	to soar
扇	shàn	fan	翻	fān	to flip
习	xí	to practice			

爪 **claw / talon** (zhǎo — claw)

抓	zhuā	to grab	爬	pá	to climb / crawl
采	cǎi	to pick			

角 **horn** (jiǎo — horn)

解	jiě	to solve / untie	触	chù	to touch
确	què	certain			

牙 **tooth / fang** (yá — tooth)

芽	yá	bud / sprout	雅	yǎ	elegant
鸦	yā	crow			

革 **leather / hide** (gé — leather)

鞋	xié	shoes	鞭	biān	whip
靴	xuē	boots			

韦 （韋） **tanned leather** (wéi — tanned leather)

* Traditional form in brackets

韧	rèn	tough / resilient	围	wéi	to surround
伟	wěi	great			

22 Shelter & Enclosures

Characters connected to buildings, roofs, and enclosing structures.

宀 roof / house (bǎo gài tóu — treasure lid top)

家	jiā	home	安	ān	safe
定	dìng	fixed	宝	bǎo	treasure
客	kè	guest	室	shì	room
富	fù	rich			

广 shelter / lean-to (guǎng zì tóu — shelter on top)

店	diàn	shop	床	chuáng	bed
座	zuò	seat	庭	tíng	courtyard
度	dù	degree / measure	康	kāng	healthy

门 (門) door / gate (mén zì kuàng — door frame)

* Traditional form in brackets

问	wèn	to ask	间	jiān	between / room
闪	shǎn	flash	关	guān	close / relate
闻	wén	to hear	闷	mèn	bored / stuffy

户 door (single) (hù zì tóu — door on top)

房	fáng	room / house	所	suǒ	place
扇	shàn	fan	扁	biǎn	flat

囗 enclosure (guó zì kuàng — enclosure frame)

国	guó	country	园	yuán	garden
团	tuán	group	围	wéi	surround
图	tú	picture / map			

穴 cave / hole (xué bǎo gài — cave lid top)

空	kōng	empty / sky	穷	qióng	poor
窗	chuāng	window	突	tū	sudden
究	jiū	to investigate			

亠 lid / top (tóu — lid on top)

京	jīng	capital	亮	liàng	bright
交	jiāo	to exchange	亭	tíng	pavilion

冂 borders / cover (jiōng — borders)

内	nèi	inside	同	tóng	same
网	wǎng	net	冈	gāng	ridge

冖 crown / cover (mì — crown cover)

军	jūn	army	写	xiě	to write
冠	guān	crown	农	nóng	farming

厂 cliff / factory (hǎn — cliff / factory)

原	yuán	original / plain	厚	hòu	thick
历	lì	history	压	yā	to press

凵 open box (kǎn — open box)

凶	xiōng	fierce	出	chū	to go out
击	jī	to hit			

勹 wrap / embrace (bāo — wrap / embrace)

包	bāo	to wrap	句	jù	sentence
勾	gōu	hook	匀	yún	even / uniform

23 Weapons & Tools

Characters connected to blades, bows, weapons, and implements.

刂 knife (side form) (lì dāo páng — standing knife side)

别	bié	don't / other	到	dào	to arrive
刻	kè	to carve / moment	前	qián	before / front
利	lì	sharp / benefit	划	huà	to plan / row
创	chuàng	create			

刀 knife (dāo — knife)

切	qiē	to cut	分	fēn	divide
剪	jiǎn	scissors	初	chū	beginning

弓 bow (gōng zì páng — bow side)

张	zhāng	to stretch / surname	弹	tán	to play / bullet
强	qiáng	strong	弱	ruò	weak
引	yǐn	to lead			

矢 arrow (shǐ zì páng — arrow side)

知	zhī	to know	短	duǎn	short
医	yī	doctor	矮	ǎi	short (height)

斤 axe / catty (jīn zì páng — axe side)

斩	zhǎn	to behead	新	xīn	new
断	duàn	to break	所	suǒ	place

殳 weapon / strike (shū — weapon/strike)

投	tóu	throw	没	méi	not have
段	duàn	section	般	bān	sort / kind
设	shè	to set up			

戈 **halberd / spear** (gē — halberd)

我	wǒ	I / me	战	zhàn	war / battle
成	chéng	to become	或	huò	or
感	gǎn	to feel	威	wēi	power / might

矛 **spear** (máo — spear)

柔	róu	soft	务	wù	affair

弋 **shoot / catch** (yì — shoot / catch)

式	shì	style	代	dài	generation
贰	èr	two (formal)			

斗 **fight / dipper** (dǒu — fight / dipper)

料	liào	material	斜	xié	slanted
科	kē	branch / subject			

24 Fabric & Thread

Characters connected to cloth, silk, clothing, and textiles.

衤 **clothing (side form)** (yī zì páng — clothing side)

衫	shān	shirt	裤	kù	pants
袜	wà	socks	被	bèi	blanket / (passive)
补	bǔ	to mend	初	chū	beginning
裙	qún	skirt			

衣 **clothing** (yī — clothing (full))

装	zhuāng	to dress / install	裂	liè	to split
袋	dài	bag	表	biǎo	surface / watch

巾 **cloth / towel** (jīn zì páng — cloth side)

帮	bāng	to help	带	dài	belt / bring
帽	mào	hat	布	bù	cloth
幕	mù	curtain	帐	zhàng	tent / canopy

纟 （糸） **silk / thread** (jiǎo sī páng — twisted silk side)

* Traditional form in brackets

红	hóng	red	绿	lǜ	green
线	xiàn	line / thread	给	gěi	to give
经	jīng	to pass / scripture	结	jié	to tie / knot
纸	zhǐ	paper			

皮 **skin / leather** (pí — skin/leather)

披	pī	to drape	疲	pí	tired
波	bō	wave	破	pò	to break

疋 **bolt of cloth / foot** (pǐ — bolt of cloth)

疏	shū	sparse / distant	蹄	tí	hoof

25 Vessels & Objects

Characters connected to containers, vessels, pottery, and everyday objects.

皿 **dish / vessel** (mǐn — dish / vessel)

盘	pán	plate	盆	pén	basin
盖	gài	lid / cover	盛	shèng	to contain
监	jiān	to supervise			

缶 **jar / pottery** (fǒu — jar / pottery)

缺	quē	to lack	罐	guàn	can / jar

鬲 **cauldron / tripod** (lì — cauldron)

隔 gé to separate

融 róng to melt / blend

鼎 **tripod vessel** (dǐng — tripod vessel)

鼎盛 dǐng flourishing (component)

臼 **mortar** (jiù — mortar)

舅 jiù uncle (mother's brother)

鼠 shǔ rat

瓦 **tile / pottery** (wǎ — tile / pottery)

瓶 píng bottle

瓷 cí porcelain

瓯 ōu small cup

鼓 **drum** (gǔ — drum)

鼓励 gǔ encourage (component)

鼗 táo hand drum

几 **table / stool** (jī — table / stool)

凡 fán ordinary

机 jī machine

朵 duǒ (measure for flowers)

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26 Transport & Direction

Characters connected to vehicles, boats, and orientation.

车 （車） **vehicle / cart** (chē zì páng — vehicle side)

* Traditional form in brackets

轮 lún wheel

转 zhuǎn to turn

软 ruǎn soft

辆 liàng (measure for vehicles)

载 zài to carry

方 **direction / square** (fāng zì páng — direction side)

放	fàng	to release	旅	lǚ	travel
族	zú	clan / ethnic	旁	páng	beside
房	fáng	room			

舟 **boat** (zhōu — boat)

船	chuán	ship	航	háng	to navigate
般	bān	sort / kind	舱	cāng	cabin

辰 **celestial / time** (chén — celestial / time)

晨	chén	morning	振	zhèn	to shake / invigorate
唇	chún	lips			

27 Writing & Knowledge

Characters connected to writing, culture, divination, and knowledge.

文 **writing / pattern** (wén — writing)

纹	wén	pattern	蚊	wén	mosquito
斑	bān	spot / stripe			

页 （頁） **page / head** (yè — page / head)

* Traditional form in brackets

领	lǐng	to lead / collar	题	tí	topic / question
额	é	forehead	顺	shùn	smooth
颜	yán	color / face			

卜 **divination** (bǔ — divination)

占	zhān	to divine / occupy	卦	guà	trigram
外	wài	outside			

士 **scholar / warrior** (shì — scholar / warrior)

壮	zhuàng	strong	志	zhì	ambition
声	shēng	sound	吉	jí	lucky

幺 **tiny / thread** (yāo — tiny / thread)

幻	huàn	illusion	幼	yòu	young / immature

爻 **lines in trigram** (yáo — trigram lines)

学	xué	to study	爽	shuǎng	refreshing

28 Health & Life

Characters connected to sickness, death, life, and vitality.

疒 **sickness** (bìng zì kuàng — sickness frame)

病	bìng	sick	痛	tòng	pain
疯	fēng	crazy	疲	pí	tired
症	zhèng	symptom	痘	dòu	pox / pimple
癌	ái	cancer			

歹 **bad / death** (dǎi — bad / death)

死	sǐ	to die	残	cán	cruel / disabled
殊	shū	special	列	liè	to arrange

生 **life / birth** (shēng — life)

产	chǎn	to produce	星	xīng	star
性	xìng	nature / gender	胜	shèng	victory

用 **use** (yòng — use)

甩 shuǎi to fling
通 tōng to pass through
备 bèi to prepare

29 Measure & Abstract

Characters connected to measurement, structure, and abstract concepts.

寸 **inch / measure** (cùn — inch)

对 duì correct / toward
导 dǎo to guide
封 fēng to seal
寻 xún to search
村 cūn village

干 **dry / stem** (gān — dry)

平 píng flat / peace
刊 kān publication
年 nián year

片 **slice / piece** (piàn — slice)

版 bǎn edition
牌 pái sign / brand

无 **without / nothing** (wú — without)

舞 wǔ to dance
既 jì already

长 （長） **long** (cháng — long)

* Traditional form in brackets

张 zhāng to stretch
帐 zhàng tent / account

高 **tall / high** (gāo — tall)

膏 gāo ointment
豪 háo heroic / bold
稿 gǎo draft

非 **not / wrong** (fēi — not / wrong)

排	pái	to arrange	悲	bēi	sad
辈	bèi	generation	靠	kào	to lean / rely on

辛 **bitter / hard** (xīn — bitter)

辣	là	spicy	辞	cí	word / resign
辨	biàn	to distinguish			

毋 **don't / must not** (wú — don't)

每	měi	every	母	mǔ	mother
毒	dú	poison			

30 Containers & Hiding

Characters connected to boxes, wrapping, and concealment.

匕 **spoon / dagger** (bǐ — spoon / dagger)

化	huà	to change	北	běi	north
匙	chí	spoon			

匚 **open box** (fāng — open box)

匹	pǐ	to match / horse	区	qū	area
医	yī	doctor			

匸 **hiding box** (xì — hiding box)

匿	nì	to hide	匾	biǎn	plaque

卩 **seal / kneeling** (jié — seal / kneeling)

印	yìn	to print / seal	即	jí	immediately
却	què	but / retreat			

厶 **private** (sī — private)

台	tái	platform	去	qù	to go
参	cān	to participate			

己 **self** (jǐ — self)

已	yǐ	already	记	jì	to remember
起	qǐ	to rise			

31 Rare & Classical

Radicals that appear less frequently in modern Chinese but complete the Kangxi set.

彐 **snout / hand** (jì — snout)

录	lù	to record	归	guī	to return
当	dāng	to serve as			

爿 **split wood / bed** (pán — split wood)

壮	zhuàng	strong	将	jiāng	will / general
状	zhuàng	condition			

禸 **track / footprint** (róu — track)

禹	yǔ	Yu (sage king)	离	lí	to leave

釆 **distinguish / pick** (biàn — distinguish)

释	shì	to release / explain	番	fān	time (measure) / foreign

隶 **slave / attached** (lì — slave)

隸	lì	slave (traditional)	康	kāng	healthy

阜 **mound / hill (阝 left)** (fù — mound / hill (阝 left))

院	yuàn	courtyard	阳	yáng	sun / positive
队	duì	team	防	fáng	to prevent
限	xiàn	limit	陆	lù	land

鬯 **sacrificial wine** (chàng — sacrificial wine)

郁	yù	fragrant / depressed

黹 **embroidery** (zhǐ — embroidery)

黻	fú	embroidered insignia

齐 （齊） **even / together** (qí — even / together)

* Traditional form in brackets

剂	jì	dose	济	jì	to cross / help

龠 **flute / pipe** (yuè — flute / pipe)

龢	hé	harmony	籥	yuè	flute

鬥 **fight / struggle** (dòu — fight / struggle)

斗	dòu	to fight	闹	nào	noisy

香 **fragrant** (xiāng — fragrant)

馨	xīn	fragrant	馥	fù	fragrance

襾 **cover / west** (xī — cover / west)

覆	fù	to cover	要	yào	want / need

耒 **plow** (lěi — plow)

耕	gēng	to plow	耗	hào	to consume

而 **and / yet / whiskers** (ér — and / yet)

需 xū to need

耐 nài to endure

鬼 **ghost / demon** (guǐ — ghost)

魂 hún soul

魅 mèi charm

魔 mó demon

Quick Reference — All Radicals by Stroke Count

Every radical at a glance, sorted by stroke count for fast lookup.

1 stroke

一 héng
horizontal stroke

丨 shù
vertical stroke

丶 diǎn
dot

丿 piě
left-falling stroke

乙 yǐ
second / turning

亅 jué
hook

2 strokes

二 èr
two

亠 tóu
lid on top

人 rén zì tóu
person on top

亻 dān rén páng
single person side

儿 ér zì dǐ
child legs on bottom

入 rù
enter

八 bā
eight / divide

冂 jiōng
borders

冖 mì
crown cover

冫 liǎng diǎn shuǐ
two dots of ice

几 jī
table / stool

凵 kǎn
open box

刀 dāo
knife

刂 lì dāo páng
standing knife side

力 lì zì páng
power side

勹 bāo
wrap / embrace

匕 bǐ
spoon / dagger

匚 fāng
open box

匸 xì
hiding box

十 shí
ten / cross

卜 bǔ
divination

卩 jié
seal / kneeling

厂 hǎn
cliff / factory

厶 sī
private

又 yòu zì páng
right-hand side

3 strokes

口 kǒu zì páng
mouth side

囗 guó zì kuàng
enclosure frame

土 tí tǔ páng
raised earth side

士 shì
scholar / warrior

夂 zhǐ
go / follow

夊 suī
go slowly

夕 xī
evening

大 dà zì tóu
big on top

女 nǚ zì páng
woman side

子 zǐ zì páng
child side

宀 bǎo gài tóu
treasure lid top

寸 cùn
inch

小 xiǎo zì tóu
small on top

尸 shī zì tóu
corpse on top

中 chè
sprout

山 shān zì páng
mountain side

巛 sān guǎi
three bends

川 chuān
river

工 gōng zì páng
work side

己 jǐ
self

巾 jīn zì páng
cloth side

干 gān
dry

幺 yāo
tiny / thread

广 guǎng zì tóu
shelter on top

廴 yǐn
long stride

廾 gǒng
two hands joined

弋 yì
shoot / catch

弓 gōng zì páng
bow side

彐 jì
snout

彡 shān
hair / bristle

彳 shuāng rén páng
double person side

氵 sān diǎn shuǐ
three dots of water

犭 fǎn quǎn páng
reversed dog side

饣 shí zì páng
food side

4 strokes

心 xīn zì dǐ
heart on bottom

忄 shù xīn páng
vertical heart side

戈 gē
halberd

户 hù zì tóu
door on top

手 shǒu
hand

扌 tí shǒu páng
raised hand side

支 zhī
branch / support

攴 pū
strike / tap

文 wén
writing

无 wú
without

木 mù zì páng
wood side

殳 shū
weapon/strike

氏 shì
clan

灬 sì diǎn dǐ
four dots on bottom

爿 pán
split wood

犬 quǎn
dog

斗 dǒu
fight / dipper

日 rì zì páng
sun/day side

欠 qiàn
owe / yawn

毋 wú
don't

气 qì
air / gas

爪 zhǎo
claw

片 piàn
slice

斤 jīn zì páng
axe side

曰

止 zhǐ zì páng
stop side

比 bǐ
compare

水 shuǐ
water

父 fù zì tóu
father on top

牙 yá
tooth

方 fāng zì páng
direction side

月 ròu yuè páng
flesh-moon side

歹 dǎi
bad / death

毛 máo
fur / hair

火 huǒ zì páng
fire side

爻 yáo
trigram lines

牛 niú zì páng
ox side

5 strokes

玄 xuán
dark / mysterious

甘 gān
sweet

疋 pǐ
bolt of cloth

皮 pí
skin/leather

矢 shǐ zì páng
arrow side

禾 hé mù páng
grain side

钅 jīn zì páng
gold/metal side

玉 wáng zì páng
king side (looks like 王)

生 shēng
life

疒 bìng zì kuàng
sickness frame

皿 mǐn
dish / vessel

石 shí zì páng
stone side

穴 xué bǎo gài
cave lid top

瓜 guā zì páng
melon side

用 yòng
use

癶 bō
footsteps

目 mù zì páng
eye side

示 shì zì páng
show/spirit side

立 lì zì páng
standing side

瓦 wǎ
tile / pottery

田 tián zì páng
field side

白 bái zì páng
white side

矛 máo
spear

肉 ròu
track

罒 sì zì tóu
four on top (net)

6 strokes

光 guāng
light

缶 fǒu
jar / pottery

而 ér
and / yet

肉 ròu
meat / flesh

臼 jiù
mortar

艮 gèn
mountain / stubborn

虫 chóng zì páng
insect side

衤 yī zì páng
clothing side

竹 zhú zì tóu
bamboo on top

羊 yáng zì páng
sheep side

耒 lěi
plow

臣 chén
minister

舌 shé
tongue

色 sè
color

血 xuè
blood

覀 xī
cover / west

米 mǐ zì páng
rice side

羽 yǔ
feather

耳 ěr zì páng
ear side

自 zì
self

舛 chuǎn
oppose / contrary

艹 cǎo zì tóu
grass on top

行 xíng
walk / go

纟 jiǎo sī páng
twisted silk side

老 lǎo zì tóu
old on top

聿 yù
brush / pen

至 zhì
arrive / reach

舟 zhōu
boat

虍 hǔ
tiger stripes

衣 yī
clothing (full)

7 strokes

见 jiàn zì páng
see side

角 jiǎo
horn

讠 yán zì páng
speech side

谷 gǔ
valley

豆 dòu
bean

豕 shǐ
pig

豸 zhì
badger / beast

贝 bèi zì páng
shell side

赤 chì
red / bare

走 zǒu zì páng
walk side

足 zú zì páng
foot side

身 shēn zì páng
body side

车 chē zì páng
vehicle side

辛 xīn
bitter

辰 chén
celestial / time

辶 zǒu zhī dǐ
walk-this bottom

酉 yǒu
wine jar

釆 biàn
distinguish

里 lǐ
village / inside

8 strokes

金 jīn
gold / metal

长 cháng
long

门 mén zì kuàng
door frame

阜 fù
mound / hill (阝 left)

隶 lì
slave

隹 zhuī
short-tailed bird

雨 yǔ zì tóu
rain on top

青 qīng
blue-green

非 fēi
not / wrong

9 strokes

面 miàn
face

革 gé
leather

韦 wéi
tanned leather

韭 jiǔ
leek

音 yīn
sound

页 yè
page / head

风 fēng
wind

飞 fēi
fly

食

首 shǒu
head / leader

香 xiāng
fragrant

10 strokes

马 mǎ zì páng
horse side

骨 gǔ
bone

高 gāo
tall

髟 biāo
long hair

鬥 dòu
fight / struggle

鬯 chàng
sacrificial wine

鬲 lì
cauldron

鬼 guǐ
ghost

11 strokes

鹵 lǔ zì páng
salt / brine

鱼 yú zì páng
fish side

鸟 niǎo zì páng
bird side

鹿 lù
deer

麦 mài
wheat

麻 má
hemp

12 strokes

黄 huáng
yellow

黍 shǔ
millet

黑 hēi
black

黹 zhǐ
embroidery

黽 mǐn
frog / toad

13 strokes

鼎 dǐng
tripod vessel

鼓 gǔ
drum

鼠 shǔ
rat

14 strokes

鼻 bí
nose

齐 qí
even / together

15 strokes

齿 chǐ

tooth

16 strokes

龙 lóng
dragon

龟 guī
turtle

17 strokes

龠 yuè
flute / pipe

Stop memorizing.
Start seeing.

Follow @lunalang42 on Threads for daily Chinese breakdowns.

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